

RANJAN RAHI

STORM OVER SIR Rahul Gandhi, Tejashwi Yadav and other opposition leaders protest the poll roll revision in Patna, Jul. 9

THE VOTER LIST CLEAN-UP

THERE ARE FOUR KINDS OF ELECTORAL ROLL REVISIONS

INTENSIVE REVISION
Fresh electoral rolls prepared from scratch with 100 per cent door-to-door verification

SUMMARY REVISION
Annual process; updates made based on claims and objections without field verification

PARTLY INTENSIVE AND SUMMARY
Mixed approach. Existing rolls published in draft while officers conduct household verification

SPECIAL REVISION
Done when routine updates are deemed insufficient. Can be attached to other methods

SPECIAL INTENSIVE REVISION: Current Bihar exercise. Not defined in electoral rules; a discretionary method created by the ECI in 2025 to validate voter citizenship

SIR's complex documentation needs, potentially preserving its voter base more effectively than its rivals. In contrast, opposition parties like the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and Congress, which rely heavily on rural and marginalised voters, do not find it as easy to mobilise support for those lacking awareness or access to required documents.

The announcement that similar exercises would follow in West Bengal and Delhi, most likely in August, reinforced perceptions of partisan intent. Opposition leaders argue that the move aligns with the BJP's long-standing narrative on illegal immigration, particularly from Bangladesh, and suspect that the voter roll purge in Bihar is a calculated effort to build legitimacy for replicating the same in Bengal, a state the BJP is trying hard to win.

RJD MP Manoj Jha led a delegation to the Supreme Court, joined by Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra, the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR) and activist Yogendra Yadav. Their petitions painted a dire picture: the SIR would disenfranchise 30 million poor, marginalised voters who lacked the specific documents demanded. On July 10, the SC allowed the ECI to continue with the SIR, but asked it to consider including Aadhaar, voter ID and ration card for verification.

Tejashwi Yadav, Bihar's Leader of the Opposition, marshalled data showing that, of the 11 prescribed documents, only three were remotely common: birth, matriculation and caste certificates. National Family Health Survey data reveal that individuals born between 1965 and 1985, now aged 40 to 60, often lacked formal birth certificates. Educational records were equally scarce, with just 10 to 13 per cent of this group having completed secondary school. The India Human Development Survey (2011-12) adds that only about 20 per cent of marginalised castes and 25 per cent of OBCs possess valid caste certificates.

Data analysis by Rahul Shastri, a researcher associated with the Bharat Jodo Abhiyan, shows that only a small fraction of Biharis aged 18-40 possess documents like passports, birth certificates, caste certificates or government job IDs. With the matriculation certificate emerging as the de facto proof of citizenship, the system effectively penalises non-matriculates, especially the poor, women and historically marginalised groups. The ECI had conducted the Knowledge, Attitude and Practices-Endline Survey, 2024, in Bihar after the previous Lok Sabha polls with a sample size of 41,913 citizens spread across 243 assembly segments. Thirty-three per cent were found to be nonliterate.

Critics also question the sudden need for SIR, as the state election machinery had completed a revision of the electoral rolls—the Special Summary Revision 2025—between June 2024 and January 2025. This runs contrary to the ECI's allusion that Bihar's existing electoral database was in such bad shape that it needed a full revamp. "A summary revision would have fully complied with legal requirements. Instead, the ECI ordered an intensive revision, requiring voters to prove their citizenship, the root cause of the current controversy," says former CEC O.P. Rawat.

BACKDOOR ENTRY FOR NRC?

The spectre of an NRC hangs over these proceedings. Asaduddin Owaisi, chief of All India Majlis-e Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM), accused the ECI of "secretly implementing the NRC in Bihar". West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee called the exercise "even more dangerous than NRC", warning it would erase rural voters and replace them with names from BJP-supporting states. Such fears stem from the fact that